

Student Name: CHEUNG, Hoi Ki

Introduction to Digital Media (EMIA2200)

Final Project Report

Basic Information

Student Name: CHEUNG, Hoi Ki (SID: 20963662)

Project Title: The Living Ink

Format : video

Runtime: 2 minutes 9 seconds (2:09)

One Sentence Description: An adventure story with a playful tone about a primary school student, whose doodle comes to life, tries to catch and stop his mischievous doodle in order to protect his homework from being ruined by the naughty doodle, while he should make the decision to erase his creation by his own hands before it is too late.

Project link

Video google drive link:

<https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1--mEKZr87FbnaQl27OOKHe3d4vGJ2Ycs>

YouTube link : <https://youtu.be/2wWz83pkyfk?si=WWZoVk8CLShdolvJ>

Artistic Statement

1. Intended message

The primary objective of my project is to explore the theme of the creator being forced to destroy their own creation. Drawing inspiration from the classic novel "Frankenstein," the project delves into the complex relationship between the creator and their creation, where the act of eliminating one's creation becomes a central dilemma.

In this video, we follow the journey of a primary school student who, feeling bored, draws a stickman for companionship. To his surprise, the stickman comes to life but ruin the student's homework. Faced with the destruction of his hard work, the student has a situation similar to Victor, the main character in "Frankenstein." Just as Victor seeks to destroy his creation due to its destructive nature, the boy's primary motive for erasing the stickman is to protect his homework.

Through this narrative, I aim to highlight the conflict and emotional turmoil experienced by creators when they are forced to confront the consequences of their creations. The boy's casual act of drawing a stickman evolves into a struggle to preserve his work and maintain control over his creation. This parallels Victor's dilemma, where he grapples with the responsibility of his creation and the potential harm it may cause.

By drawing parallels to "Frankenstein," my project aims to provoke thought and engage viewers in considering the relationship between creators and their creations, the consequences of unchecked ambition, and the potential for revenge or retribution from the creations themselves.

Ultimately, the message of my project is to emphasize the complex nature of creation and the weight of responsibility that creators bear. It serves as a reminder that creation, whether in the form of art, ideas, or inventions, comes with a level of accountability. It encourages contemplation of the choices we make as creators and the potential consequences that may arise from our creations.

2.Idea & Project Details:

The project incorporates several notable elements and considerations that contribute to its overall structure and execution. Here are the key points to mention:

1. Structure: The story is divided into four parts, following the structure of traditional Chinese poetry known as "起承轉合" (qi cheng zhuan he). This structure can be identified through the background music used in each section. The first three parts feature different background music, while the last part, the "ending," has no background music. This structural approach adds rhythmic element to the storytelling.

2. Addition of Homework-Tearing Scene: Originally not planned until writing the whole story script, the inclusion of a scene where the boy tears his homework was a deliberate decision to establish one of the climactic moments in the video. It makes the story more intense in the middle and also showcases the impulsiveness and rashness often associated with young students, adding depth to the character and intensifying the overall narrative.

3. Adaptation of Animation Techniques: Initially intending to use stop motion animation throughout the entire project, as mentioned in Challenges and Risks part in the final project plan. Yet, a decision was made to prevent the boy and the moving stickman from appearing on the same screen, as achieving desired camera movements using stop motion is difficult. Therefore, in the scenes where the boy and stickman are together in a shot, the stickman remains stationary. Given the focus on the plot and the overall scene, this subtle compromise is acceptable, particularly in this fast-paced two-minute short film.

These details showcase the thought process and adjustments made during the project's development, and the adaptation of animation techniques to achieve the desired visual effects.

Reflection on the digital media technologies

Technology #1: Stop-motion animation

Software: Stop Motion Studio **PRO**, Remote Camera (An app that let you use another device to shoot the photo in Stop Motion Studio **PRO**)

Justification: stop motion animation for Stickman movement

Expectation vs Reality:

Initially, I underestimated the time required for stop motion animation, assuming it would be a quicker process. However, I soon realized that it consumed nearly 70% of my project time,

surpassing the time spent on video editing and filming the live video. The reason behind this was the constant drawing and erasing of the stickman in each shot. During the erasing process, I often unintentionally moved the camera setup, necessitating a complete retake of the entire scene, which became increasingly frustrating.

Additionally, to maintain a consistent background while animating, I had to secure the camera in a fixed position. Lacking a camera stand or tripod, I made do with random things found around my home to hold my phone. Consequently, I faced limitations in terms of camera angles for the stop motion animation, as I could only shoot from restricted perspectives.

Furthermore, I opted to use an erasable pen instead of a pencil to draw the stickman, but this decision presented an issue. Repeatedly drawing and erasing the stickman at the same spot on the paper resulted in paper damage, making it even more difficult to redraw on the same surface. As a result, I had to use a fresh sheet of paper for each shooting session.

Given the numerous unexpected challenges I encountered, the duration of each stop motion animation scene ended up being relatively short. Despite my efforts, the complexities and limitations posed by the process affected the length and intricacy of the individual scenes.

Technology #2: Digital Editing and Effects

Software: Capcut

Justification: Editing of the entire video, combining the live video I shot with iPhone 11 and the stop motion animation, including visuals and audio

Expectation vs Reality:

Since I had a clear vision of the video's structure and filming approach during the project planning phase, the editing process proceeded smoothly. I simply divided the raw footage into clips, assembled them, and incorporated appropriate sound effects. To enhance the video, I used free background music in the library of the app. To ensure a balance in screen time and emphasize the presence of two main characters, I inserted live video segments between the stop motion animation clips. Fortunately, my prior experience with this editing software facilitated a smooth editing process overall.

Reflection on the feedback after presentation

I decided to remove the blackout scene at the beginning of the video, taking into consideration feedback from my classmate and agreeing with his opinion that it was redundant.

While editing, I attempted to synchronize the scenes with the background music. However, I encountered limitations in making extensive changes to the video arrangement or modifying the background music. Since I had already made significant progress in completing the entire video, any subtle alteration had the potential to disrupt the overall delivery and impact of the project.

